

# The Velvet War of Silkstrand

A Prequel Adventure for Fate's Edge

The last testament of the Silk Coin

Year of the Falling Bridge



# Prologue: The Fall of the Silk Coin

*They were not great. They were not remembered. They were thieves who kept their word — and for that, the Velvet Court burned their guildhouse to ash.*

*Old Kes, their fence, was the first to fall. A Livaeen oath turned his blood to honey and his heart to lead. He betrayed them with a kiss.*

*The Silken Blade, masked and smiling, cut them down one by one. A poisoner, a ghost, a silver-tongued liar — all fell holding a stairwell so that the children could run.*

*Eight ran. Eight carried nothing but a broken sword, a lockpick, a fox, a ledger, a scroll, a medicine kit, a toolkit, a letter. Eight swore never to return.*

*This is their story. But it is also the story of those who did not run.*

*If you are reading this, you have chosen to begin at the beginning. The prequel adventure, **The Velvet War of Silkstrand**, follows. The players will create the fallen — heroes who die so the exiles may live.*

*If you prefer to start with **Blood and Silk**, skip to the next chapter. The Legacy Tokens will be awarded as flashbacks. The road remembers both.*



# How to Run This Prequel

## A Note on Tragedy

This is not a standard adventure. The player characters are **doomed**. They will not survive the final act. Their goal is not victory but *delay* — to buy time for the pre-generated exiles of *Blood and Silk* to escape. Embrace the tragedy. Let each death be a choice, each sacrifice a gift to the future.

The mechanics support this: scripted death scenes, Legacy Tokens, and a visible **Court's Net Timer** that ticks inexorably toward the guildhouse's fall.

*The Velvet War of Silkstrand* is a Tier II–III prequel adventure, designed for 3–5 players who will create original members of the **Silk Coin**, a small, principled thieves' guild. The pre-generated characters from *Blood and Silk* (Kestra, Benjamin, Sariel, Elena, Thane, Lyra, Finn, Zara) appear as junior members — apprentices who witness the heroes' final stand.

## What the Players Should Know

- The Silk Coin was once a modest guild of fence, smugglers, and honest thieves.
- Their patron is **Old Kes**, a fence who taught them the trade.
- The **Velvet Court** is a ruthless syndicate that now demands the Silk Coin's territory.
- A mysterious power — tied to a brothel called **The Gilded Pillow** — is turning the Court's enemies into willing collaborators.

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## 0.1 The Tragedy's Shape

The adventure unfolds in three acts:

1. **Act I – The Silk Coin's Last Score:** The guild attempts a heist to buy Old Kes's freedom. It is a trap.
2. **Act II – The Hunt:** The Velvet Court systematically destroys the Silk Coin's allies, resources, and safe houses.
3. **Act III – The Burning Guildhouse:** The final assault. The pre-gens escape through a hidden tunnel while the player characters hold the line.

Player characters **will die**. The only question is how many of the eight pre-gens survive — and what Legacy Tokens they carry into *Blood and Silk*.

## 0.2 New Mechanics

### 0.2.1 Desperation Dice

When a player character is at **Harm 2** (their second wound), they may roll an extra d10 on any action. On a roll of 1–9, the action proceeds normally. On a **10**, they succeed spectacularly but immediately take their third wound (incapacitated). This represents a last, heroic burst.

### 0.2.2 Court's Net Timer (Visible)

| Timer Segments | Effect                                                                    |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0–2            | The Court is probing. Safe houses are still hidden.                       |
| 3–4            | A contact is turned. One Safe House is lost.                              |
| 5–6            | The guildhouse is surrounded. No one enters or leaves without permission. |
| 7              | Reinforcements arrive (Black Banner mercenaries).                         |
| 8              | The final assault begins.                                                 |

The timer advances when:

- The party fails a Stealth or Subterfuge roll (+1).
- The GM spends 2 *to represent the Court's intelligence network* (+1).
- A player character is captured or killed (+2).
- The party lingers in one location for too long (GM's discretion, +1).

### 0.2.3 Legacy Tokens

At the end of the adventure, the GM awards **Legacy Tokens** based on how many pre-gens escape:

- **8 escape (heroic):** 3 Legacy Tokens.
- **6–7 escape:** 2 Legacy Tokens.
- **Fewer than 6:** 1 Legacy Token.

Each token becomes a **minor Asset** in *Blood and Silk*, chosen by the players who played the prequel. Examples:

- *Elena's Medicine Stash* – A hidden cache of rare herbs (+1 die to Medicine rolls once).
- *Benjamin's Worn Sword* – A blade that never dulls (ignore one *Compromised* tag).
- *Sariel's Lockpick Set* – +1 die to open any lock that was touched by a Silk Coin member.
- *Thane's Toolkit* – Can repair one piece of *Compromised* gear without a roll.
- *Lyra's Diplomatic Papers* – A forged letter of introduction to a Vilikari lord.
- *Finn's Fox Companion* – A Cap 1 follower that can sniff out danger.
- *Zara's Ledger* – A list of Velvet Court contacts (grants +1 die to Streetwise in Silkstrand).
- *Kestra's Scroll* – A one-use Rite of the Traveler (any low rite).

## 0.3 Factions and Key NPCs

### 0.3.1 The Silk Coin (Player Characters)

A small guild of 3–5 thieves, each with a specialty. Players should create their own characters using the *Fate's Edge* core rules (Tier II, 50–70 XP). Suggested archetypes:

- **The Mastermind** (Wits, Subterfuge, Command) – plans the heists.
- **The Ghost** (Wits, Stealth, Ikasha rites) – infiltration.
- **The Blade** (Body, Melee, Athletics) – muscle.
- **The Silver Tongue** (Presence, Sway, Livaea rites) – social infiltration.
- **The Tinker** (Wits, Craft, Tinker) – traps and devices.

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### 0.3.2 The Pre-Gens (Non-Player Characters)

These eight are junior members, not yet full thieves. They have Cap 1 skills and no Talents. Their role is to be *protected* and *evacuated*. The GM should describe their fear, their hope, and their growing admiration for the player characters.

### 0.3.3 The Velvet Court

**Madam Serafine** (Tier IV, off-screen) – The Court’s true ruler. She is never seen directly, but her influence touches every scene. She speaks through intermediaries, always cloaked, her face hidden by a velvet veil. Her voice is warm, reasonable, and utterly without mercy.

**The Velvet Enforcer (Antagonist)** – A Cap 3 opponent who leads the attacks. She wears a silver mask and fights with a poisoned stiletto. Her name is never revealed; the Court calls her *the Silken Blade*.

**The Gilded Pillow (Livaeen Brothel)** – A front for the Court’s intelligence network. The courtesans are Livaeen cultists who extract secrets from clients. Entering the Pillow with hostile intent triggers a (the goddess protects her own). The players may discover that Old Kes’s betrayal was compelled by a Livaeen *Unrefusable Offer* he could not refuse.

### 0.3.4 Old Kes (Terrestrial Patron, Betrayer)

The Silk Coin’s mentor and fence. He is captured in Act I, but the twist in Act III reveals he was never captured — he *offered* himself as bait. Livaea compelled him with an oath he could not break. His betrayal is not malice; it is desperation. He loved the Silk Coin. He also loved his daughter, who is held hostage at the Gilded Pillow.

### 0.3.5 Mareth (Secret Ally)

The hooded scholar from *Blood and Silk* appears in Act III, guiding the pre-gens through the canal tunnels. She does not fight. She only whispers: *"This way. I knew your teachers. They asked me to keep you safe."* She does not explain how she knew.

# 1 Act I — The Silk Coin's Last Score

## 1.1 Opening Scene — Old Kes Is Taken

The adventure begins in the Silk Coin's guildhouse, a converted spice warehouse near the Dye Yards. Old Kes was supposed to return at dawn. He did not. A terrified messenger — a street urchin the guild protects — arrives with a bloodied note: *"The Bronze Ledger. One night. Or Kes hangs."*

The Bronze Ledger is a blackmail book kept by Madam Serafine herself. It contains secrets of every major official in Silkstrand. Stealing it is suicide.

But the Silk Coin has no choice.

## 1.2 Scene 1 — The Guildhouse

Introduce the player characters and the pre-gens. Ask each player to describe their character's relationship with one pre-gen (e.g., *"I taught Kestra how to pick a lock."* or *"Benjamin once saved my life from a Watch patrol."*). These relationships become Bonds that generate Boons later.

The pre-gens are:

- **Kestra** — copying scrolls in a corner, her fingers stained with ink.
- **Benjamin** — sharpening a sword, brooding.
- **Sariel** — perched on a windowsill, watching the street.
- **Elena** — tending a wounded urchin.
- **Thane** — working a forge, muttering about ventilation.
- **Lyra** — reading a letter from her family, then hiding it.

- **Finn** — stroking a grey fox with a missing ear.
- **Zara** — counting silver, her face pale.

### 1.2.1 The Bronze Ledger — Planning the Heist

The players have one night to case the Velvet Court's headquarters, a mansion in the Patrician Heights. The GM should run this as a **heist planning montage** using the mechanics from *The Velvet Touch*. Each player describes one preparation (casing the guard patrol, bribing a servant, mapping the sewers). Each strong success on a Setup roll (Wits+Stealth or Wits+Streetwise, DV3) grants +1 Position or -1 DV later.

The players learn that the Bronze Ledger is kept in a lead-lined safe in Serafine's private study. The study is guarded by a  inscribed with Livaea's sigil — a kiss and a thorn.

### 1.2.2 The Heist — A Trap

Run the heist as a series of challenges. The players succeed in reaching the safe — but the ledger is not there. Instead, they find a single sheet of parchment: "*Welcome. The Court has watched you for a year. Tonight, we collect.*"

The mansion's doors lock. The  turns hostile (burns any non-Livaeans for 1 Fatigue per round). The players must escape. Use the pursuit rules from *Violets and Stone* (Chase through Patrician Heights, DV 3–5). On success, they return to the guildhouse with a few minor ledgers (enough to buy a day). On failure, one player character is captured (they will be rescued in Act II).

**End of Act I — Court's Net Timer advances to 2.**

## 2 Act II — The Hunt

### 2.1 Opening Scene — The Pillow House’s Whisper

A contact tells the Silk Coin that Old Kes was seen entering the **Gilded Pillow**, a Livaeen brothel, the night before his disappearance. The Pillow House is neutral ground — no violence is permitted within its walls. But secrets are not.

The players may infiltrate the Pillow House using social skills (Presence+Sway, Presence+Performance). A successful roll reveals that Kes was not imprisoned — he *volunteered*. A courtesan (a Livaeen priestess) confesses under pressure: *"His daughter is here. She serves the goddess now. Kes would do anything to free her."*

If the players investigate further, they uncover that the *Unrefusable Offer* was used on Kes. He cannot disobey. His betrayal is a tragedy, not a treachery.

#### 2.1.1 The Court’s Retaliation

The Velvet Court strikes back. Use a series of short, brutal vignettes:

- **The Fence is Taken:** The Silk Coin’s secondary fence is arrested. The Watch arrives with a warrant signed by a Censor who owes the Court.
- **The Safe House Burns:** A fire in the Dye Yards destroys a hidden cache of supplies. The players may rescue the pre-gens from the flames.
- **The Informant is Turned:** A trusted ally sells the guild’s patrol schedules. The Court’s assassins ambush a player character on a lonely bridge.

Each vignette ticks the **Court’s Net Timer** by +1. The GM should let the players attempt to mitigate the damage (e.g., bribing the Censor, fighting the assassins) but the timer *will* advance.

### 2.1.2 The Betrayal Revealed

Old Kes meets the players in secret — in the catacombs beneath the Gilded Pillow. He is gaunt, his eyes hollow. He confesses everything: Livaea's compulsion, his daughter's captivity, his hopelessness.

He offers one last gift: the combination to the Bronze Ledger's backup safe, hidden in his own warehouse. He also warns them: *"The Court's net closes at dawn. Get the children out."*

If the players spare him, he helps them escape. If they condemn him, he accepts his fate. Either way, he does not survive the night.

**End of Act II — Court's Net Timer at 5 or 6.**

## 3 Act III — The Burning Guildhouse

### 3.1 Opening Scene — The Night Before

The guildhouse is surrounded. The players have one hour to prepare. They can:

- **Barricade the doors** (Body+Craft, DV3) – ticks the final assault back by 1 segment.
- **Send the pre-gens to the canal tunnel** (Wits+Stealth, DV4) – buys time for the escape.
- **Negotiate with the Court** (Presence+Sway, DV5) – a false offer; the Court will betray them.
- **Write a letter** – each player may write a short note to a pre-gen. This becomes a Legacy Token.

#### 3.1.1 The Final Assault

The Court sends its best: the **Silken Blade** (Cap 3, Harm 3, Stealth 4, can poison) and a squad of Black Banner mercenaries (Cap 2 squad). The players must hold the entrance while the pre-gens escape through the tunnel.

Run this as a **scripted combat**. The players cannot win. Instead, they choose how to spend their remaining resources:

- **Spend a Boon** to delay the Court for one round.
- **Sacrifice a Limb** – permanently reduce an Attribute by 1 to save two pre-gens.
- **Use a Desperation Die** – as described above. A 10 means a spectacular last stand.

### 3.1.2 Mareth's Arrival

Midway through the battle, a hooded figure appears at the canal entrance — **Mareth**. They do not fight. They simply wave the pre-gens forward. *"This way. I knew your teachers. They asked me to keep you safe."*

The pre-gens hesitate. The player characters shout at them to run. They run.

### 3.1.3 The Last Stand — Player Character Deaths

Each player character gets a **final scene**. Describe their death in as much detail as they wish. The GM may ask: *"What is the last thing you see?"* or *"What do you say to the children as they flee?"*

When all player characters are down, the GM describes the guildhouse collapsing. The Court's enforcers walk through the flames, searching for survivors. They find none of the pre-gens.

### 3.1.4 Epilogue — The Canal

The pre-gens emerge from a storm drain on the river's edge. They are ragged, silent. Mareth is gone. Kestra finds a note pinned to a post: *"Go west. Do not look back. The road will teach you."*

They look back. The sky above the Dye Yards is red.

One of them — Benjamin, perhaps — speaks: *"They bought us time. We'll not waste it."*

They walk.

## Awarding Legacy Tokens

At the end of the session, the GM awards Legacy Tokens based on how many pre-gens escaped (all eight, by default, unless the players chose to sacrifice some). Each player chooses one Legacy Asset to appear in *Blood and Silk*. The GM notes these for the campaign.

# 4 Appendix — NPC Quick Stats

## 4.0.1 The Silken Blade (Velvet Court Enforcer)

Tier III. Body 3, Melee 4, Stealth 4. Talents: *Poisoned Blade* (on a hit, target tests Resolve DV3 or gains 1 Fatigue), *Shadow Meld* (Ikasha's rite), *The Velvet Glove* (can call a minor NPC as a distraction). Harm 3.

## 4.0.2 Old Kes (Broken Fence)

Tier II. No combat. Offers Strings (*Kes's Warehouse Key*, *Kes's Last Ledger*). Under Livaea's compulsion; cannot resist a direct order from a Courtesan.

## 4.0.3 Livaeon Courtesan (Gilded Pillow)

Tier II. Presence 3, Sway 3, Performance 2. Rites: *Golden Tongue*, *The Unrefusable Offer* (once). Will not fight; will try to seduce or bargain.

## 4.0.4 Mareth (Mysterious Ally)

No combat. Wits 4, Lore 4, Traveler's rites. Does not speak of their past. Appears only to guide the pre-gens.

## 4.0.5 Black Banner Mercenary (Squad)

Cap 2 squad. Body 3, Melee 2, Athletics 2. Harm 2 per squad member. Two squads are present in the final assault.



## 5 Colophon

This account was written by the last surviving clerk of the Silk Coin, on paper salvaged from the burning guildhouse. The ink is lamp-black and ash. The binding is a torn ledger cover.

The coin was spent. The debt was paid. The road remembers.